other celebrated centres of Buddhist learning and practice, such as Kucha, Balkh and Bamiyan (in present-day Afghanistan) where Indian monks lived and preached. The famous Kumarajiva, who translated a large number of Buddhist scriptures into Chinese during the fifth century CE , came from Kucha. Kucha was known in Tang China as a rich oasis town where people from Persia, India and China mingled and enjoyed a varied cultural life. In Tang China, a popular song was the ‘Love Song of the Ganges River’, which had been carried by musicians from Kucha. Some surviving frescoes from the ruins of Kucha depict colourfully clad dancers swirling away while musicians play on the lute, flute and drums.

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Several caravan routes threaded their way across Central Asia during the first millennium. The starting point for the routes from China was the ancient capital of Changan, present-day Xian, where the famous terracotta warriors of the Qin dynasty (321–206 CE) have been excavated. From there the route went west, crossing the Kansu corridor, a narrow passageway that lies between the Mongolian steppes to the north and the Tibetan highlands to the south. The Kansu corridor leads to the Taklamakan desert, entry to which is through the oasis town of Dunhuang and then through the fortress of Jiayuguan, which is the western starting point of the Great Wall of China. All caravans from China passed through this point and then into the inhospitable Taklamakan desert.

From here there were two routes traversing the northern and the southern rims of the desert and passing through a number of oasis towns. The southern route, which was used by Fa Xian on his outward journey, went to Loulan, Karashahr, Khotan, Tashkurgan and the Darel before crossing into Swat and Taxila in northern India. The northern route, which was used by Xuan Zang, went from Dunhuang to Hami (famous for its honey melons), Turfan, Kucha, Karashahr, Tashkend (Tashkent), Samarkand, Balkh, Bamiyan, Kapisi (near Kabul) and on to Taxila. From Taxila one could travel to Kashmir or to Peshawar (then known as Purushapur). From Taxila one could also travel to Mathura and then on to what the Chinese called the